

Churchill War Rooms - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Secret Bunker

Right now you are standing inside one of the best-kept secrets of the whole Second World War. You came down the steps by Saint James's Park on a hot afternoon, and the air suddenly turned cool, didn't it? That is because you have climbed down into a bunker, a hidden underground fortress, buried beneath a big stone government building. For six years, while bombs fell on London, this is where a small group of people helped run an entire war.

Here is how it started. In the 1930s, Britain could see trouble coming. A man named Adolf Hitler was in charge of Germany, and his armies were growing. Everyone knew that if a new war came, this time enemy planes could fly over London and drop bombs from the sky. The government needed a safe place to keep working even while the city above them was being attacked. So they looked underground, into the basement of a strong building near the Houses of Parliament, and quietly began turning it into a secret headquarters.

They finished just in time. These rooms became ready for action on the twenty-seventh of August, 1939, and just one week later, Britain was at war. From that day, one room down here never closed. Not once. It was called the Map Room, and someone was on duty in it every single hour of every single day for six whole years. The lights stayed on the entire time. Imagine a light switch that nobody turns off for six years.

The people down here worked while air raids roared overhead. They couldn't see the sky, so they never quite knew if it was day or night. And when the war finally ended in 1945, something strange happened. They simply switched off the Map Room lights, closed the doors, and walked away, leaving maps on the walls and pencils on the desks, exactly where they were. The bunker fell asleep. It stayed like that, frozen in time, for nearly forty years, until it was finally opened up so that visitors like you could walk through it. Everything you see around you is real. Keep your eyes open.

The Giant Slab of Concrete

When these rooms first opened, there was a scary problem. A bunker is only useful if it can keep you safe, and honestly, at the start, this one couldn't. It was just an ordinary basement. If a really big bomb had landed on the building above, the ceiling could have come crashing down on everyone inside. The people working here knew it, too. That takes a certain kind of brave, doesn't it? Going to work every day in a place you're not sure will hold.

So in the autumn of 1940, while German planes were bombing London night after night, the builders came in and did something clever. Above these rooms they poured a gigantic layer of concrete, and they nicknamed it "the Slab." In some places it was up to five feet thick. That is taller than you are. Picture a solid block of concrete stretching over the whole ceiling, thick enough that a grown-up couldn't see over it. That Slab turned a wobbly basement into a proper fortress.

Once people felt safer, the bunker grew. They dug out and added more and more rooms, until it was

about three times bigger than when it started. It became a whole underground village, with bedrooms, a kitchen, offices, and long, narrow corridors, all hidden under the street.

But here is the funny thing. Even with the mighty Slab, the top people secretly worried it still might not survive a direct hit from the very biggest bombs. They didn't tell the workers that, of course. Everyone just kept calm and carried on, which was rather the British way. As you walk, run your eyes along the low ceilings, the fat pipes, and the thick doors. This wasn't a comfortable place. It was built for one job only, to keep the people who ran the war alive.

Frozen in Time

Here's one of my favourite things about this place. Almost nothing you see is a copy. When the war ended in the summer of 1945, the people who worked down here didn't pack up neatly. They just stopped. They turned off the Map Room lights for the first time in six years, shut the doors, and went home to sleep in real beds under a real sky. And then, for years and years, hardly anyone came down.

The bunker sat in the dark, forgotten, gathering dust. Sugar was still in a drawer. Pins were still stuck in the maps. A calendar on a wall still showed a wartime date. It was like a moment of history had been trapped in a jar. A few people knew it was here and quietly looked after it, but the public wasn't allowed in.

Then, finally, in 1984, the doors were opened for good, and ordinary visitors could walk these corridors for the very first time. The people in charge of it, a famous place called the Imperial War Museum, were very careful to keep everything exactly as it had been left. So when you look through the glass into these rooms, you are not looking at a pretend film set. You are looking at the real thing, more or less untouched since 1945.

Later on, they added something you should absolutely go and find. It's a whole museum about Churchill himself, with a huge table right in the middle, about fifteen metres long. It's called the Lifeline, and it's like a giant interactive timeline of his entire life. You can touch it and make things happen. See if you can find the day he was born, and the day he became the leader of the country. Go on, this cool underground finale has one more surprise waiting for you.

The Man Who Kept the Secret

Here is a puzzle for you. How do you build a secret headquarters in the middle of a busy city, fill it with beds and desks and telephones and tins of food, and make sure that almost nobody finds out? You can't exactly order a hundred bunk beds and have a lorry drop them at the front door of a government office. People would notice. People would talk. And in wartime, a secret that leaks can get people killed.

The answer to that puzzle was one clever, quiet man, and his name was George Rance. He wasn't a famous general. Before the war he had one of the most boring-sounding jobs you can imagine, sorting out the pay for the cleaning ladies in a government building. But he was trusted, and he was careful, and it turned out he was brilliant at keeping a secret.

Mister Rance was put in charge of turning the basement into the bunker, and he had a sneaky trick. Whenever he needed something, chairs, filing cabinets, all the bits and pieces to fit out the rooms, he would slip his order in alongside the ordinary, allowed orders, asking for a few extra. And he had all the extra things delivered to a special address, care of Mister Rance. That little phrase, care of Mister Rance, became a kind of magic password. Anything sent to it was quietly carried down into the secret rooms, and nobody asking questions ever learned where it really went.

And here is the best part. Mister Rance held the only set of keys. Think about that. The whole beating heart of the British war effort, and the keys to get in lived in one man's pocket. If you wanted through

those doors, you went through him.

So as you walk, spare a thought for George Rance. Kings and generals get statues, but wars are also won by careful people doing quiet, unglamorous jobs perfectly. He guarded this secret so well that even years later, most of London had no idea these rooms existed at all. After the war, he was given a special honour by the King for his trouble. Not bad for the man who used to count the cleaners' wages.

The Day the Lights Went Out

Every story needs an ending, and this bunker has one of the strangest endings of all. Let me take you to the very last days, so you can picture how it happened.

On the eighth of May, 1945, the war in Europe finally ended. Germany had surrendered. Up above your head, out in the streets of London, the whole city went absolutely wild with joy. People poured outside, complete strangers hugged each other, they danced and sang and lit bonfires, and church bells that had been silent for years rang out all over the country. It was called V E Day, short for Victory in Europe. After nearly six years of fear, the bombs were finally over.

But down here in the bunker, on that same happy day, the work did not quite stop. Because the war wasn't completely finished. Far away, across the world, Britain and its friends were still fighting Japan. So while London partied above them, a small handful of people in the Map Room kept right on working, tracking that faraway war, just as they always had.

They carried on for three more months. And then, in the middle of August, Japan surrendered too. The Second World War was over at last, everywhere in the whole world. Someone in the Map Room walked over to the calendar on the wall and marked the date, the sixteenth of August, 1945. And that date is still there today. Go and look for it. It's the last day anyone was really on duty down here.

Then they did the simplest, most ordinary thing. They switched off the Map Room lights, the very same lights that had burned without stopping for six whole years, and they locked the doors, and they went home. No big ceremony. No speeches. Just a click of a switch, and darkness, and quiet, for the first time since 1939.

And that quiet lasted a very, very long time. So when you stand in the Map Room and look at that final date on the calendar, you are looking at the exact moment this place fell asleep. You caught it, all these years later, still dreaming.

Churchill the Man

Every bunker needs a boss, and the boss of this one was one of the most famous, most stubborn, most surprising people who ever lived. His name was Winston Churchill, and I want to tell you about him, because he was not a perfect hero from a storybook. He was something more interesting, a real person, funny and brave and grumpy and flawed, all at once.

Winston was born in 1874 in an enormous palace, into a very posh family. But he was not a star pupil. At school he was often near the bottom of the class and got into trouble, and he had a lisp that made some words hard to say. Grown-ups thought he'd never amount to much. He spent his whole life proving them wrong.

As a young man he became a soldier and an adventurer, galloping into battles in faraway countries and writing exciting newspaper stories about them. He was captured once, in a war in South Africa, and locked up as a prisoner. He escaped, all by himself, over a wall and across hundreds of miles of enemy land. He became famous before he was thirty.

Then he went into politics, which is the business of running a country, and here's the surprising part. For years and years, hardly anyone listened to him. People thought he was old-fashioned and wrong. He kept warning that Hitler was dangerous, and everyone rolled their eyes. Those were his lonely years, when he seemed finished.

But when the war came and things looked truly terrible, Britain suddenly needed exactly his kind of stubbornness. In May 1940, at sixty-five years old, an age when many people stop working, Winston Churchill became Prime Minister, the leader of the whole country. And he turned out to be brilliant at the one thing that mattered most, refusing to give up, and making everyone else believe they could win too. Remember his face as you go. He was here, in these very rooms.

The Words That Fought Back

Winston Churchill had a secret weapon, and it wasn't a gun or a tank. It was words. When he became Prime Minister in 1940, France had fallen to the Germans, enemy armies were just across the sea, and lots of people thought Britain would lose. Churchill couldn't magic up more planes or soldiers overnight. But he could stand up and speak, and when he spoke, something happened to people. They stood a little taller.

He was honest, which was unusual. In his very first speech as leader, he didn't promise everything would be easy. He said all he could offer was "blood, toil, tears and sweat," which means hard work, pain, and no shortcuts. And somehow, that honesty made people trust him more, not less.

A few weeks later, when things looked their darkest, he made a speech promising that Britain would never surrender. "We shall fight on the beaches," he said, listing all the places they would keep fighting, on and on, until you believed it. And then he told the whole country that if they were brave now, people would look back in a thousand years and say, "This was their finest hour." Their finest hour. Imagine being told that your scariest moment could also become your proudest.

He often growled these speeches slowly, in a deep, rumbling voice, and millions of people crowded around their radios to listen. Some historians say his words were worth as much as an army. He practised them for hours and grumbled and rewrote them until every line was just right. So the next time you feel like giving up on something hard, remember the grumpy old man in the bunker who won partly by refusing to sound afraid, even when he was.

A Funny, Flawed Giant

Now, let me tell you the funny, human bits, because Churchill was full of them. He almost always had a fat cigar sticking out of his mouth, even down here in the bunker. He loved them. He also invented his own comfy outfit, a sort of all-in-one zip-up suit a bit like a giant babygrow, which he called his “siren suit.” He’d wear it to important meetings and not care one bit what anyone thought.

He worked at the strangest hours. He liked to stay up very late into the night and then have a nap in the afternoon, and he did loads of his work from his bed, propped up on pillows with papers everywhere. He was famous for being demanding and impatient, and he could be grumpy and say unkind things. Like all real people, he wasn’t perfect, and he made big mistakes too. It’s okay to admire someone and still know they had faults.

Here’s the part that surprises everyone. After Churchill led Britain to win the war, the country had a vote, and they picked a different leader. Imagine winning the biggest fight of your life and then, weeks later, being told it’s time to go home. He was disappointed, but he didn’t disappear. A few years later the people changed their minds and made him Prime Minister all over again.

He was also a brilliant writer, so good that in 1953 he won the Nobel Prize in Literature, one of the biggest prizes in the whole world for writing. When he finally died in 1965, as a very old man, the entire country stopped to say goodbye, with a gigantic funeral watched by millions. Not bad for a boy who was near the bottom of the class.

The Great Escape

I promised you Churchill was full of surprises, so settle in, because I’m going to tell you the whole story of the most thrilling thing that ever happened to him, and it happened long before the bunker, when he was just twenty-four years old. It’s a proper adventure, with a train ambush, a daring escape, a wanted poster, and nine days on the run. Every word of it is true.

Back in 1899, young Winston wasn’t a politician yet. He was a newspaper reporter, sent to write about a war in South Africa. One morning he climbed aboard an armoured train, a train covered in metal plates like a fortress on wheels, to go and see the fighting up close. Bad idea. The enemy, soldiers called the Boers, ambushed it. They rolled boulders onto the tracks, and the train smashed into them and came off the rails. Bullets pinged off the metal. Winston, brave and reckless as ever, jumped out into the gunfire and helped clear the track so some of the men could escape. But there were too many enemy soldiers. He was caught, marched off at gunpoint, and locked up as a prisoner of war in a school building far behind enemy lines.

Now, most people would have sat tight and waited. Not Winston. He hated being trapped more than almost anything. So one dark night, he waited until the guards weren’t looking, took a deep breath, and climbed over the prison wall. Just like that, he dropped down on the other side, into enemy country, completely alone. He had no map. He barely spoke the language. He had a bit of chocolate in his pocket and a few coins, and hundreds of miles of hostile land between him and safety. Gulp.

The next morning, the enemy discovered he was gone, and they were furious. They printed a wanted poster and offered a reward to anyone who caught him, dead or alive. And here is the funny, cheeky part that Winston loved to tell for the rest of his life. The reward they offered for him was just twenty-five pounds. Twenty-five pounds. He was rather insulted, actually, that they didn’t think he was worth more.

So there he was, a hunted man with his face on a poster, trying to cross enemy land without being spotted. He walked at night and hid by day. And then he had an extraordinary stroke of luck. Exhausted and desperate, he knocked on a random door in the dark, and by pure chance it belonged to an Englishman, a

mine manager, one of the very few friendly faces for miles around. The man took him in, and then hid him in the last place anyone would look. Down a coal mine. Deep underground, in the pitch black.

Winston spent days hiding down that mine, in the damp and the dark, with rats scuttling over him in the gloom. Imagine it. The future leader of Britain, curled up in a black tunnel underground, listening to rats, waiting, hoping nobody would find him. It's almost funny that a man who would one day hide from bombs in an underground bunker first learned to hide underground down a coal mine.

Finally, his new friends smuggled him out. They hid him on a freight train, buried under heavy bales of wool, and he rattled along for days, holding his breath every time the train stopped, praying nobody would climb up and search the load. And it worked. The train crossed the border out of danger, and Winston Churchill popped out, filthy and grinning, a free man.

By the time he got home to Britain, he was famous. Everyone had read about the daring young man who escaped. It was the start of the whole rest of his life. So next time you feel stuck, remember the twenty-four-year-old who climbed the wall, hid from the rats, and never, ever gave up.

Life Below Ground

Close your eyes for a second and imagine actually living down here. No windows. No sunshine. The same electric lights buzzing day and night. Air that smells of dust, cigarette smoke, and cigars. The distant thud of bombs shaking the ground above you. That was normal life for the people who worked in this bunker, and there were more of them than you might think.

It wasn't just Churchill and his generals. There were dozens and dozens of ordinary workers down here. Typists clattering away on typewriters, telephone operators connecting calls, clerks moving pins on maps, cooks, cleaners, and soldiers standing guard. Many of them were young women, not much older than a big brother or sister, and some of them practically lived underground for weeks at a time. They slept in cramped bunk beds in the lowest, hottest, stuffiest level, which they nicknamed "the Dock." It was so deep and airless that people said it was miserable, full of the sound of snoring and the smell of everyone crammed together.

Because there was no sunlight, people down here started to get ill. Our bodies need sunshine to stay healthy, so the bunker had special sun lamps, like little indoor suns, and workers would sit in front of them to soak up pretend sunshine. Some of them even got sunburnt underground, which must be one of the strangest ways to get a sunburn ever.

There were secret little tricks to help everyone cope. On the wall was a special sign, a weather board, but it wasn't really about rain. When it said "windy," that was a code. It didn't mean it was breezy outside. It meant bombs were falling right now, up above their heads. That way the people deep in the bunker knew what was happening in the world they couldn't see. As you walk, look for the small, human clues these people left behind. They turned this cold concrete box into a home.

The Toilet That Was a Lie

I'm going to tell you about the sneakiest room in the whole bunker, and it might make you laugh. Somewhere down here there is a door with a sign on it that says "engaged," the word you see on a toilet when someone is inside. For years, almost everyone who worked here believed that behind that door was Churchill's own private toilet. His special loo. They thought he was very lucky to have his own.

But it was a trick. It was one of the best-kept secrets in the entire building. Behind that door was not a toilet at all. It was a tiny, secret telephone room, and it held the most important phone in the whole bunker.

This special phone let Churchill talk, in complete secret, all the way across the ocean to the President of the United States of America. Britain and America were friends fighting on the same side, and their two leaders needed to talk without any enemy spies listening in. So the phone used an enormous, top-secret scrambling machine that jumbled their voices up into gibberish, then unjumbled them at the other end. The machine was so gigantic it couldn't even fit down here. It was hidden far away, under another building.

Think about how clever the disguise was. If a stranger somehow sneaked into the bunker and saw a door marked "engaged," they'd just think, "Oh, someone's in the toilet," and walk right past the most secret room of all. Nobody guards a loo, do they? When you find that little room today, remember this. The fate of the whole free world was sometimes decided in a place everybody thought was just a bathroom.

Secrets in the Walls

This bunker is full of tiny secrets, and the people who explored it much later found little surprises everywhere, like a treasure hunt through history. Let me share some of my favourites, so you can go hunting for them too.

First, the Map Room phones. There's a row of coloured telephones, white and green and one for the outside world, and the workers nicknamed them the "beauty chorus," like a line of dancers in colourful costumes, because back then telephones were nearly always boring black. But here's the clever bit. These phones didn't ring. Churchill hated noise and needed to think, so instead of ringing, the phones lit up and flashed silently when someone was calling. A quiet, blinking rainbow of urgent messages.

Next, look for the doodle. Somewhere on one of the maps, the story goes, a bored worker secretly drew a tiny cartoon of Hitler, sprawled on the ground doing a silly cross-eyed salute. Nobody knows for sure who drew it, or exactly when, which makes it even more fun. It's a cheeky little joke, hidden in a very serious place, waiting all these years for someone to notice it.

And here's a sweet one, literally. Long after the war, someone opened an old desk drawer and found sugar cubes still tucked inside, left there and forgotten when the workers walked out in 1945. In wartime, sugar was precious and hard to get, so people saved every scrap. Whoever hid those cubes clearly meant to come back for them one day, and never did.

So as you go, be a detective. The pins, the flashing phones, the little Hitler doodle, the forgotten sugar. Every single one is a fingerprint left behind by a real person who lived down here in the dark.

The Girl Who Typed for Churchill

Let me introduce you to a young woman who worked down here, because her story helps you imagine what it was really like. Her name was Elizabeth Layton, and she was in her twenties, and she had grown up partly in Canada, a long way across the ocean. One day she answered an advertisement looking for someone to type for the Prime Minister, and suddenly, there she was, working for the most famous man in Britain.

Now, typing for Churchill was not an easy job, and I'll tell you why. Winston hated noise when he was thinking. He couldn't stand the clatter of an ordinary typewriter going clack clack clack while he was trying to find the perfect words. So Elizabeth had to use a special silent typewriter, a clever machine that whispered instead of clacked. And Churchill worked in a way that would make your head spin. He didn't write things down and hand them over. He simply spoke, out loud, fast, marching up and down or lying in bed, and Elizabeth had to catch every single word and type it instantly, perfectly, with no mistakes. The very first time she met him, she made one tiny error, and he was not pleased at all. She had to learn quickly.

Imagine the pressure. The great man is pacing, the words are pouring out, sometimes it's a world-changing speech, sometimes it's orders that will send ships across the sea, and you cannot cough, cannot pause, cannot ask him to slow down. You just have to be brilliant, quietly, in the background. Elizabeth did it for years, and later she wrote a whole book about what it was like. That's partly how we know all these little details today.

She wasn't the only one keeping this place running, of course. Think about the telephone operators, mostly young women too, sitting at a big switchboard, a wall covered in little holes and wires and plugs. Every time someone wanted to make a call, an operator had to grab the right wire and plug it into the right hole to connect them. All day, all night, calls to generals, calls to ships, calls to the other side of the world, all passing through the quick fingers of a young woman at a switchboard deep underground.

And here's a job I bet you've never thought about. Every single morning, before nine o'clock, the people in the Map Room gathered up everything that had happened in the war overnight and wrote it into one short report. And that report went straight to the King himself, so that when King George the Sixth woke up and had his breakfast, he already knew exactly how the war was going. Every single day. Somebody down here had to get it right, on time, no excuses, before most of London had even had their toast.

So as you look around, don't just picture Churchill. Picture Elizabeth catching his words on her silent typewriter, and the operators plugging in their wires, and the person writing the King's morning report. This place ran on hundreds of ordinary young people, doing extraordinary jobs, in the dark.

London at War

When you climb back up these steps into the sunshine, you'll be standing in a city that once went through something almost impossible to imagine. Try this. Look around at London today, busy and bright and full of tourists. Now picture it in 1940, in the dark, holding its breath, waiting for the bombs to fall. Because for months, night after night, they did.

The Germans sent wave after wave of planes to bomb London, trying to frighten Britain into giving up. People called this terrible time the Blitz. It began in September 1940 and went on and on, all through that autumn and winter. When the sirens wailed, families grabbed their things and hurried to shelters. Some hid in cellars, some in special metal cages in their gardens, and thousands of Londoners slept deep underground in the Tube stations, curled up on the platforms while the city shook above them.

Every night the whole city went dark on purpose. It was called the blackout. No street lights, no glowing windows, nothing, so enemy pilots high above couldn't find their targets. People hung thick black curtains and stumbled around in pitch darkness. Imagine your whole town switching off every single light, every night, for years.

And here's something that might tug at your heart. Because London was so dangerous, huge numbers of children, kids about your age, were sent away from their parents to live with strangers out in the safe countryside, with just a little suitcase and a name label tied to their coats. It was called being evacuated. Some had a lovely time, and some were homesick and miserable. Now imagine being a grown-up in this bunker, working to protect a city full of families, knowing children had to be sent away for their own safety. That is what these quiet rooms were really fighting for.

Related listening: The dome that survived the Blitz and the bunker that directed the fight are one story. Listen back — “St Paul’s: The Dome That Refused to Burn” (St Dunstan & St Paul’s, Day 3). Related listening: The same war on two fronts: London’s bunker and the fortress island guarding the Forth. Coming up — “Seals, Seabirds and Secret War Tunnels” (Inchcolm Island & Forth Bridge, Day 10).

Bombs, a Palace, and a Miracle

Do you remember Buckingham Palace, where you stood this very morning? Here's something amazing about it. During the Blitz, even the King and Queen's palace was bombed. Enemy planes dropped bombs right onto it while the King and Queen were actually at home inside. They could have run away to safety in the countryside, like many rich people did. But they refused. They stayed in London, in their bombed palace, to be with their people.

The Queen said something that Londoners never forgot. After the palace was hit, she said she was almost glad, because now she could look the poorest, most bombed-out families in the eye and say, we are all in this together. That's a pretty brave thing to say while bombs are falling on your own roof.

And do you remember Saint Paul's Cathedral, that gigantic dome you saw on Monday? On one of the worst nights of the whole Blitz, so many bombs and fires rained down that it looked like the entire city was burning. Brave volunteers climbed all over Saint Paul's, putting out the flames before they could destroy it. And in the morning, a photographer took a picture of that great dome standing tall and untouched, floating above all the smoke and fire. That photo went everywhere. It became a symbol that said, London is still here, we are not beaten.

So this morning you saw a palace that took a bombing and didn't flinch, and on Monday you saw a

cathedral that survived a night of fire. You've been walking past the bravery of 1940 all week long without even knowing it.

How Close It All Was

I want to be honest with you about something, because you're old enough to understand it. In the summer of 1940, Britain came terribly close to losing. After Hitler's armies had marched across Europe, Britain was almost the last free country still standing against him, an island on the edge, all alone. Everyone genuinely feared that German soldiers might come across the sea and invade, marching through the very streets you're standing on. It was that close.

What saved Britain first was a battle fought entirely in the sky, called the Battle of Britain. Young pilots, some of them barely out of school, climbed into little fighter planes and fought the much bigger German air force, high above the fields of southern England, to stop the invasion. They were so outnumbered that Churchill said the whole country owed everything to these few brave pilots. And, incredibly, they held on. The invasion never came.

But the danger didn't end there. Later in the war, the enemy invented horrible new weapons, flying bombs and rockets that came without warning. The rockets were the scariest, because they fell from so high and so fast that you couldn't even hear them coming until they exploded. Londoners had to be brave all over again.

Here's the big idea to carry back up those steps with you. The people in this bunker didn't know they were going to win. Nobody had told them the ending. They just kept working, day after day, in the dark, choosing to hope. That is the real reason this quiet, cool, concrete place is one of the most important spots in all of London. Ordinary people, in an extraordinary time, simply refused to give up.

Sent Away

I want you to imagine something, and really try to feel it, because it happened to hundreds of thousands of children about your age. Imagine your mum or dad packs you a tiny suitcase. Inside is a change of clothes, your toothbrush, maybe one favourite toy. They pin a label onto your coat, like a parcel, with your name written on it. They hang a cardboard box around your neck with a gas mask inside, in case of a poison-gas attack. And then they take you to a railway station, kiss you goodbye, and send you off on a train to live with total strangers in a village you have never seen. You don't know where you're going. You don't know when you'll come home. And your parents are not coming with you.

That really happened. It had a name, Operation Pied Piper, and it began right at the start of the war, in September 1939. Over the course of just a few days, more than a million people were moved out of the dangerous cities, and around eight hundred thousand of them were children. Whole schools emptied out at once. Picture entire classes, teachers and all, marching to the station together, everyone with a label and a gas-mask box, waving at parents through the train windows.

Where did they all go? Out to the countryside, to farms and small villages far from the bombs, to be looked after by families called host families. But here is the part that could feel a bit like being at a market. When the trains arrived, the children were often lined up in a village hall, and the local grown-ups walked along the row and picked the ones they wanted to take home. Brothers and sisters sometimes got split up, one family choosing the girl, another taking the boy. Imagine standing in that line, hoping someone kind picks you, and hoping they pick your sister too.

And the truth is, it went all sorts of ways. Some children landed with warm, loving families and had the adventure of their lives. For a city kid who had never seen a real cow or a proper starry sky, the countryside could be pure magic, fresh eggs, muddy boots, space to run. But other children were desperately homesick,

crying into their pillows at night, missing their mums, sometimes stuck with hosts who didn't really want them or weren't very kind. It depended entirely on luck.

Some children were away for a few weeks. Some were away for years and years, growing taller, losing baby teeth, having birthdays, all far from home. And when they finally came back at the end of the war, imagine that moment. Some of them had been so little when they left that they barely recognised their own parents at the station. Some had picked up new country accents. Some had grown so much that their mums gasped. It was joyful and strange and a little bit sad, all at the same time.

So here is why I'm telling you this in the bunker. The grown-ups working down here in the dark, moving pins on maps, writing reports, staying up all night, they were doing it for exactly those children. Every decision made in these cold concrete rooms was, in the end, about getting all those labelled, gas-mask-carrying kids safely back home to their families. That was what the whole thing was for.